sooner or later. The Bajpai–Patel–Menon view was that 'sooner is better', while the Nehru–Panikkar view was that 'later is better'. The sooner school wanted to link a final Tibet agreement to a border settlement, from the beginning; the later school wanted to wait until China raised the border issue. The sooner school assumed it was better to engage Beijing when China was relatively weak and preoccupied with internal consolidation (e.g., in Tibet) and external challenges (in Korea, in Taiwan, and in relation to the US). The later school assumed that notwithstanding China's challenges, India faced perhaps even greater challenges, both internal (e.g., national integration and governance capacity) and external (Pakistan, Cold War pressures). In the end, the later school prevailed. Three months after the two sides signed an agreement in 1954 in which Delhi gave up its rights in Tibet, Nehru decided not to broach the subject of border definition when he met his counterpart Zhou Enlai on 25–28 June 1954.

Both sides in the Indian debate had a plausible view, and neither side was 'idealistic'. Both accepted that eventually differences over the border would arise and would have to be candidly discussed with Beijing. Both recognized that Indian capacities and control in the borderlands had to be expanded: on this Bajpai–Patel–Menon and Panikkar–Nehru were agreed. However, the sooner school thought it was better to know what India was up against early in the relationship, whereas the later school wanted to give China and India time to settle into a relationship, to use diplomacy to build goodwill, and to increase Indian political and military capacities in the borderlands. Given the depth of differences with China that were to appear in the years ahead, the sooner school probably had it right. To be fair, though, the later school had a case, given that India had just come out of a war with Pakistan in 1948, was dealing with the consequences of Partition, and constructing a new constitutional, political, and economic order.

We know much less about Chinese thinking on the border in these early days after the communists took power. This is largely because of the paucity of sources. China did open its archives briefly after the Cold War, but quickly closed them again. Chinese and Western scholars used that opportunity to write about the period, but their focus was elsewhere: